could be trodden on by the feet of everyone entering it' until such time as the emperor remembered his old affection for the man and released him. The following year it was another officer, Muzaffar Khan, who developed an attachment for a smooth-faced youth and Akbar had the boy removed from court. Scholar Rosalind O'Hanlon has shown that there was a certain racial stereotyping of Uzbeks by the Mughals with both Abu'l Fazl and Badauni talking of 'the filthy manners of Transoxiana', while referring to homosexual attachments deemed 'neither burning nor melting, neither love nor friendship'. A certain homoerotic sensitivity was admitted by the Mughals, but of a rarefied and exalted sort, preferably leading to the writing of charming couplets. It was not considered within everyone's power to control it and keep it within acceptable boundaries as Jalal Khan had demonstrated.

Much more worryingly for Akbar, however, was news of the Uzbeks' renewed efforts to foment rebellion in the eastern regions. Ali Quli Khan had not only had the khutba read out in Mirza Hakim's name, he had also had coins minted, all irrefutable signs of a treacherous realignment. Efforts at peace and compromise had clearly failed and Akbar spent a month gathering his forces before leaving, at the beginning of summer in May 1567, at the head of an army of 2,000 war elephants. At Rae Bareli, Akbar decided to take the shortest route, through forested scrubland, and arid, benighted tracks, so that by the time he reached Manikpur, there were only eleven courtiers left with him. When they reached the Ganga, it was rumbling and frothing with rain water as the monsoon had begun but Akbar plunged into the river on his elephant, forcing his courtiers to do the same. Behind them, three elephants in their train, Khuda-Baksh, Bal-Sundar, and Toofan-Masti, bellowed and trumpeted in agitation and the men rejoiced, seeing in this a sign of imminent victory. After his forces had caught up, Akbar attacked. In the final confrontation with the Uzbek clan, there were 500 Mughal soldiers and 500 war elephants and the Uzbeks were finally decisively routed. Ali Quli Khan was thrown off his horse and crushed by an elephant which 'ground his bones to powder and made his body like a bagful of chess-pieces'. Bahadur Khan Uzbek was captured and decapitated and the heads of the two Uzbek brothers were sent to Agra. The soldiery would be forgiven, treated simply as brave and valuable warriors who were not responsible for their generals' choices, but there would be no clemency this time for the officers and Akbar reserved the strongest punishments for